



Paperweight Player

LUCKNOW Loyalty pays, especially when the benefactor is none other than BJP president Rajnath Singh. By appointing Ramapati Ram Tripathi as the BJP's Uttar Pradesh state chief, the party seems to be trying to woo back its former vote-bank, the Brahmins.

Tripathi, neither an orator nor a manager, has been a nominated member of the legislative council for more than a decade, thanks to his loyalty to Singh. He has never contested an election and

yet has been entrusted with the responsibility of leading the party in the next Lok Sabha elections.

The BJP leadership had been scouting for a new party president in the state since May after Kesarinath Tripathi quit from his post in the wake of the drubbing the BJP received in the recent Assembly polls. Rampati's name came out tops from three others shortlisted for the post—former Uttar Pradesh BJP chief Kalraj Mishra, Kisan Morcha chief Vinod Pandey and

REWARDED: Tripathi's

loyalty has paid off

former minister Mahendra Nath Pandey. Tripathi qualified on two counts—that he is a Brahmin and a Rajnath Singh loyalist. The BJP president himself represents the Thakurs, the second-largest majority in the upper caste segment.

But apparently the BJP doesn't grasp that the Brahmin votes went to the BSP because of its strong leadership and a solid vote bank of Dalits. The BJP lacks both a charismatic leader and a support base. Hence, it is incorrect to assume that merely foisting a Brahmin leader would revive the party. In any case, the BJP was routed in all the three seats that went to by-polls on August 29.

How a state party chief who has never contested an election will fare against heavyweights like BSP supremo and Chief Minister Mayawati and SP president Mulayam Singh Yadav promises to provide new material for the Great Indian Laughter Challenge. **by Subhash Mishra**

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Former Union minister **Mohammad Shafi Qureshi**, as the chairman of the National Minorities Commission. He replaces Mohammed Hamid Ansari following his election as Vice-President of India.

DIED: Scientist and former director-general of the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research **Ashesh Prosad Mitra**, 81. He was awarded the Padma



Bhushan in 1989 and was involved in ionospheric and related atmospheric research.

DIED: Dr Rangaswamy Narasimhan, the designer of India's first general purpose digital computer and a doyen of Indian computer science research.

LAUNCHED: ISRO's **Geo-synchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle F04**, India's third operational gslv in orbit, carrying the 2,130 kg communications satellite Insat-4CR.

VIS-A-VIS **I. S. BINDRA** Punjab Cricket Association president **versus** **KAPIL DEV** Former India cricket captain

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Poaching players from an existing system and claiming to be a missionary is duplicity. He (Kapil) is putting money over country.
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SAURABH SINGH

“
The BCCI pretends to be a democracy when they really are a dictatorship. They are ruthless with players.
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EPILOGUE: The war of the willows takes on the colour of money, but the game remains to be played.